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ARTICLE

College Students Are Still Hungry for Something The Culture Cannot Give Them



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 21, 2026

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More than 700 students made decisions to follow Jesus at Appalachian State University last week. After the gathering, about 100 were baptized.

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The scene has been repeated at campuses across the country. At the University of Miami, students responded to the Gospel and were baptized after a UniteUS outreach. Pepperdine University has also seen a large student response. Since its first event at Auburn University in 2023, UniteUS says it has reached more than two dozen campuses and more than 100,000 students.

A packed arena and students stepping into the water make for powerful images. But the deeper story may be what they reveal: College students are still hungry for something the culture cannot give them.



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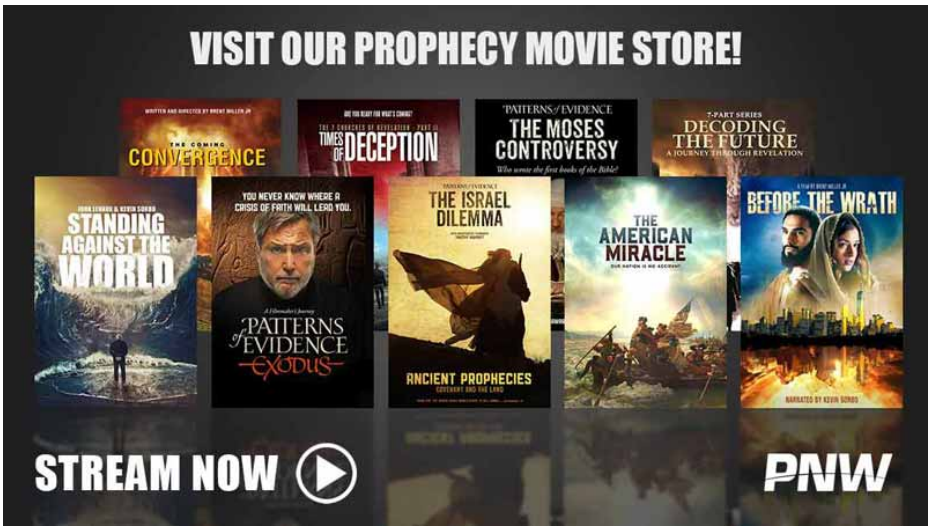
A Generation Still Asking the Big Questions

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rounded by constant noise, competing messages and promises of fulfillment that can leave them more anxious and alone. They are told nd a purpose and define truth for themselves. Yet those answers often raise more questions than they settle.

A night of worship and a clear presentation of the Gospel offer something different: truth, purpose, forgiveness and the hope of belonging to Christ.

That hunger should not surprise Christians. Every generation needs the good news of Jesus. Still, it is easy to assume young adults have moved beyond faith, or that they are too distracted to listen. Students filling campus venues challenge that assumption. They are showing up, worshiping and listening. According to UniteUS, many are also making decisions to follow Christ.



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When Faith Goes Public

The baptisms are especially moving because they make a decision visible. Students step into the water before their peers to identify themselves with Jesus. One student wrote after the App State gathering that there was "nothing more beautiful than watching people publicly declare their faith through baptism."

In a culture that often treats Christian belief as outdated or embarrassing, that public step carries meaning. These students are not simply attending a concert or watching from the stands. They are saying, in front of friends and classmates, that they have decided to follow Jesus.

But the moment in the water is not the end of the story. A powerful event can open a door; it cannot replace the lifelong work of learning to follow Christ.

The Work Begins After the Arena Empties

New believers need more than memories of a packed arena or a moving worship set. They need the Word of God, prayer, Christian friendship and a church community that will walk with them through the questions and pressures ahead. Jesus called His followers not only to make disciples, but to teach them to obey everything He commanded.

That responsibility belongs to the whole church. Campus ministries can open doors and proclaim the Gospel. Local congregations, pastors and mature believers can help students keep growing once the event is over and ordinary campus life resumes. A student who raises a hand or enters the water should not have to figure out the next steps alone.

The reports from App State, Miami and Pepperdine suggest that many young adults are willing to hear the message of Jesus. The church must be ready to help them follow Him.

The next outreaches will be held at the University of South Alabama on October 27 and in Nashville at Belmont University on November 10.

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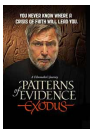
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